Lincoln Street in downtown Ithaca, south of Cayuga Lake.

Once they had moved into the apartment, his friend Ken Keoughan asked Ratan to accompany him to the grocery store to buy provisions. A surprised Ratan looked at him as if he had gone ‘nuts’ and replied: ‘I don’t go to grocery stores.’ An astonished Ken told him that if he insisted that he would not go, ‘you’re not gonna have any [thing] to eat’, startling Ratan into joining him. It was yet another step towards his transformation into an all-American kid. Soon he was at ease nibbling on loaves of bread and gulping down mugs of coffee, with the latter habit persisting to this day, though now in moderation.

Despite all the fun that Ratan had at Cornell, if he disliked anything, it was the cold weather. He had to sit in class in his cold, wet shoes, feeling miserable. It is not that he did not try being adventurous in the snow. When he picked up the courage to try skiing, it ended up as a disaster. While he was told to ‘hang on’ to the skis of his roommate, Ken Keoughan, he held it in front so close and ‘had stuck his tongue to the steel edge of the ski and it was stuck’ and it took some ‘ingenuity’ to get it ‘unstuck’.

And when he did ski, Ratan recalled: ‘I spent most of that afternoon in my backside sliding down, having fallen.’ This misadventure ended Ratan’s romance with snow once and for all.

Participating in all its activities, Ratan melted into the fraternity culture of Cornell University and is today its celebrated member. In 2008, he became the second of the two alumni who were awarded the Distinguished Merit Award. The first was Samuel Bodman (US secretary of energy, 2005–09) who got the award in 2006.

For the Love of Architecture

Although Ratan was enrolled in the mechanical engineering programme, deep down he was still disappointed that he could not pursue architecture. His near-obsession with architecture made him choose elective courses closely connected with the subject. ‘Architecture was very much in my heart, and even when I was in mechanical engineering, I took up an elective course in industrial design,’ he says. After two years at Cornell, he threw down the gauntlet and shifted to the BArch programme. He was overjoyed that he now had the opportunity to pursue his heart’s desire. Ratan gave up